parliamentarian—he joined the BJP only in 2016. His elevation as deputy CM in 2022 showed he had secured his niche as one of the party's most recognisable Brahmin leaders, vital to balancing the BJP's recent OBC-ward tilt.

But the situation has not been without hints of lobby politics. Deepotsav was no isolated instance; Yogi's current term has seen recurring signs of unrest and division. One episode played out in Kanpur in June, when a feud between a district magistrate (DM) and chief medical officer (CMO) over corruption allegations spiralled into a larger political fracas

Takeaways

- **Deputy CMs Keshav Maurya, Brajesh Pathak absent from key event**
- **Episode reignites talk of divisions within the Yogi administration**

that exposed rifts within the BJP. One section, including Speaker Satish Mahana, backed the CMO; the support of Pathak, who's also the health minister, was implied. Another group, supporting the DM, escalated the matter to the CM's office. The Samajwadi Party, watching from the sidelines, lost no time suggesting that it reflected friction between Yogi and Pathak.

In the past two years, at least half a dozen ministers—including Pathak as well as Ashish Patel, husband of Union minister Anupriya Patel—have also clashed or publicly voiced frustration with the state bureaucracy. As the BJP looks ahead to the 2027 assembly election, much will depend on how Yogi manages his deputies and ministers, and whether his authority unites the organisation or begins to stretch it. ■



PLAY CALLED OFF Broadcasters pack their bags at Bakshi stadium; below, Muslims and Pandits play a friendly after 35 years in August

▶ KASHMIR

Heaven's Premier League Vanishes Into the Blue

Match interruptions have never been so shambolic. A whole tournament gets run out as organisers scoot

By **Kaleem Geelani**

KASHMIR'S GOLDEN CHINAR FALL, flecked with chrysanthemum, was getting some flamboyant cricket colours too this season. But a whole league—a copy of the prized IPL packaged as the Indian Heaven Premier League (IHPL)—vanished overnight into the autumn on November 2. A motley crew of dumbfounded international stars like Chris Gayle and Jesse Ryder, umpires and match officials were stuck in their hotel rooms, at the high-end Radisson Collection, due to unpaid bills. And Srinagar's Bakshi stadium saw an empty ground and stands, clueless broadcasters packing their equipment, shocked catering agencies wrapping their goodies with tarpaulin to ship them out.

Why? The organisers of the private league, a non-profit called the Yuva Society of Mohali from Punjab, ditched Srinagar half-way through a 15-day tournament, a week ahead of the scheduled November 8 final.

Slow to ignite on tinglingly cold evenings, the T20 league was beginning to generate some steam—or so it seemed. After all, there were the likes of Gayle, Ryder, Thisara Perera and Devon Smith playing alongside local talent. Like the IPL, there were eight teams slugging it out, with cheering